Somehow, I keep thinking of this line from ‘Frasier’ tonight.

With one hand, the past moves us forward. And with the other, it holds us back.

Father and mother landed in Newark last week. They were supposed to visit me till Thanksgiving. In the last two weeks, I had imagined them taking walks through the woods near the house, marveling at the reflections in the water underneath the bridge, and admiring the Chapel Hill foliage that led someone to call it the ‘southern part of heaven’. But father has caught a bad flu and has been in the hospital for three days in New Jersey. The folks at the hospital will likely discharge him tomorrow, but father and mother are considering flying back soon after he recovers, likely never to return to this country.

I feel like I am in mourning, though I do not know what I mourn.

Do I grieve for what will not happen? That mother and father will not experience the North Carolina summer in my garden, seeing their grandchildren chase after fireflies they call ‘cheenta lights’? That they will never see the house they were excited that I was going to buy? That the large downstairs bedroom, which in my head was always theirs, will never see them live in it? Like wind moving through the forest, homes gather the whispers of our lives. Perhaps I grieve that mother and father will never share this part of me. But then, there are many parts of me that are alien to them. I do not grieve, for example, that they will never share my love of numbers, or any of my professional life. Perhaps what I really grieve is that this part of me will be untouched by their memories, the bedroom overlooking the garden will be a husk of what it could have been. And Dev and Nina will not know their grandparents as part of their everyday lives, their memories etched into the rhythms of childhood.

Perhaps it is more than my parents that I am mourning. It is the loss of the bridge with the family that I left behind, my brothers and the home we shared. If my parents were not to be back, what happens to my dreams of my brothers visiting me, with their families in tow. So many times, after I bought this house, I have mentally assigned rooms for them. In some way, the house held a promise—a possibility where the distances between us would be crossed. Instead, I fear it may become a reminder of the widening gap between my life here and the one that I left behind.

But perhaps what I really grieve is mortality, pressing quietly but now so coldly. Time is no longer on my side. In my mind, I had months and years that I could have spent together with mother and father. Our time together will never again be long and leisurely, and it will always feel limited by the ticking of a clock I cannot slow.

In some ways, all my mourning feels premature and foolish. The grief is not for something that is lost, but paths that will remain unwalked. After all, it is not any tragedy that robs me of these, but the quiet passage of time. And yet, is it not a terrible tragedy that the future, like the past, is always slipping away.